prohibition by the ruler of all things forbidden by the sharia and a jihad against followers of other religions. The jiziya tax imposed on all non-Muslim subjects would have been considered essential in further debasing non-believers and shackling their ability to live a luxurious life. However, in a country like India this sort of strict adherence to the sharia would have been politically catastrophic. The Sultans of Delhi (thirteenth to sixteenth century) had pragmatically ignored many of the injunctions of the sharia but none of the dynasties preceding the Mughals had been able to successfully establish themselves for a significant period of time. But the Mughals, and most especially Akbar, were positively cavalier in their attitude towards the ulema and the sharia and much more willing to find innovative ways in which to integrate their non-Muslim subjects into the empire. Akbar dispensed with the jiziya early on in his reign, and it would remain abolished almost continuously for a further hundred years.

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Given the range and breadth of his achievements, and his indisputable claim to be regarded as one of India's greatest monarchs, and one of the very greatest in world history, it is surprising that few full length biographies have been written about Akbar in modern times. There are a great many scholarly works, certainly, about aspects of his life and reign, and a trove of primary material, but this has not resulted in comprehensive studies of his life and reign. The scholarly works have often delved deeply into particular aspects of Mughal rule, but there are no recent accessible accounts of many of the Mughal emperors, not to mention of the most remarkable of them all. This is perhaps unsurprising, for most great Indian monarchs remain in dusty obscurity lit up palely only in the light of scholarly texts. Where the Mughals are concerned, moreover, modern writings have been heavily influenced by ideology—as we can see in the nationalist writings of the early twentieth century, and the Marxist analyses of mid-twentieth-century scholars. More recently, popular narratives of suspect scholarship have veered sharply towards the identification of the Mughal Empire with the infamous notion of one thousand years of oppression of Hindus.

Be that as it may, in recent years, there has been a very welcome spike in interest in historical writing, both fiction and non-fiction. Perhaps as a nation, as we attempt to come to terms with our complex heritage, we are taking a close look at the past, to understand it as well as our present. It is therefore essential that we are able to go beyond infantilizing binaries that